THE EIGHTH OF MAR CHESHVAN · RESISEI LAYLA, SIMANIM 5, 27 AND 21

Faith in the Night

What my mother and Rav Tzadok understood about the bigger picture, for the thirty-sixth yahrzeit of Yenta Rivka bas Rav Yaakov Halevi

Thirty-Six Years

I was fourteen when my mother, Yenta Rivka bas Rav Yaakov Halevi, known to everyone as Yetta Gutnicki, passed away. Her yahrzeit, the eighth of Mar Cheshvan, begins this Sunday evening. It will be thirty-six years.

She had ovarian cancer for five and a half years. I have spent most of my life since trying to say what those years were, and the truest thing I can say is that they were not lost years. My mother loved all of us, and despite the challenges she gave us every ounce of herself, every fiber, so that we would have a great life. She did not give us whatever the illness left over. She gave through it.



My bar mitzvah, at thirteen, about a year before my mother's passing.

More than anything else, she taught us the bigger picture. She treated every second as the most valuable thing there is, and she did not get that from a book. She learned it

when her own father passed away young, and she understood from the inside what actually matters in a life and what does not.

But the bigger picture for her was never only about time. Her deepest aim, the thing every ounce of effort was pointed at, was that her children would have a real connection to Hashem. She wanted us to know where life comes from and where it is going.

This year, while working on my edition of *Resisei Layla* by Rav Tzadok HaKohen of Lublin, I went looking for the teaching that says what she lived. I expected to write about the opening pages. Instead the book pulled me forward to three other places, and in each of them I found my mother's life described in Rav Tzadok's language.

A Man Who Wrote From the Night

Rav Tzadok HaKohen of Lublin was a nineteenth-century Chassidic master, and one of the deepest Jewish thinkers of his age. His own life was not the one anyone would have designed. As I have learned it, his first marriage did not last, and his second marriage never brought children. A man in that position could have written a book of lament. He could also have written a book of bitterness, or explanation, or complaint.

He did something else. He understood life on a bigger scale, and he wrote for the Children of Israel: how an ordinary Jew, in an ordinary week of work and worry, can live a real and eternal life. In a very real sense his *sefarim* became his children. And what comes through in everything he wrote is the same thing underneath it all: a settled joy, and an unshakable sense that everything comes from Hashem.

The name of this book carries the whole idea. *Resisei Layla* means "the droplets of the night," from the Song of Songs: "my head is filled with dew, my locks with the drops of the night."[1] It is a book of small drops of light, gathered in the dark.

1 Song of Songs 5:2. "I was asleep, but my heart was awake; … my head is filled with dew, my locks with the drops of the night."



Resisei Layla, Volumes I and II — the published Akiva Publishing editions.

That is what I want to share with you in my mother's memory, in three parts. They come from Simanim 5, 27 and 21.

Faith Is the Work: Siman 5

The fifth siman opens with a sentence that is almost startling in how plain it is.

> "Man's primary occupation in this world is faith."
>
> עִיקַּר עֵסֶק אָדָם בָּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה הוּא הָאֱמוּנָה
>
> **— Resisei Layla, Siman 5, Seif 1**

Not the main thing we *believe*, but the main thing we *do*. Faith is the job. He then ties it to a verse from the Psalm for Shabbos: "And Your faithfulness in the nights."[2] Rav Tzadok

2 Psalms 92:3, from the Psalm for the Sabbath day. Rav Tzadok connects it with Menachot 29b, "With the letter *hei* this world was created," which he reads as the attribute of faith, the final *hei* of the Divine Name.

notes that this world is compared to night.[3] The night is not a punishment. It is where faith is needed, and so it is where faith is made. In daylight you see. At night you trust.

And what does that trust sound like, in the moments when it is hardest to hold? Rav Tzadok gives a counsel so simple that it is easy to read past.

> "During the time of a person's immersion in this world, let him never let go, at the very least, of the simple faith that everything is from Hashem, blessed be He, and there is none besides Him."
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> בְּעֵת שִׁיקּוּעַ הָאָדָם בָּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה ... אַל יָזוּז מִמֶּנּוּ עַל כָּל פָּנִים אֱמוּנָה הַפְּשׁוּטָה ... דְּהַכֹּל מֵהַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ וְאֵין עוֹד מִלְבַדּוֹ
>
> **— Resisei Layla, Siman 5, Seif 1**

Everything is from Hashem. He does not say it will feel good, or that it will be understood. He says to hold on to that one thing at the very least, while the rest of life is at its most absorbing and its most dark. He describes a person who "receives his sustenance and his pleasures from Hashem, even while his work is down in obscurity," and he applies to such a person the verse "the righteous shall live by his faith."[4]

> "... and he receives his enjoyments from Hashem, blessed be He, even while his work is in darkness; about this they said: 'The righteous shall live by his faith.'"
>
> וּמְקַבֵּל הֲנָאוֹתָיו מֵהַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ ... הַגַּם שֶׁהוּא בְּמַחְשָׁךְ מַעֲשֵׂהוּ ... צַדִּיק בֶּאֱמוּנָתוֹ יִחְיֶה
>
> **— Resisei Layla, Siman 5, Seif 1, citing Habakkuk 2:4**

Rav Tzadok even tells us what the practice looks like in daily life. It is the blessing. When we say *Baruch atah*, "Blessed are You," we switch from talking about God to talking *to* Him, in the second person. He explains that the Sages instituted the blessing so that, before a person sinks into any pleasure, he stops and addresses the Giver directly, and recognizes that all of it comes from Him.

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3 Rav Tzadok cites Pesachim 2b for the comparison of this world to night. He adds that the darkness is the evil inclination, which "darkens," and cites Kiddushin 30b.

4 Habakkuk 2:4. Rav Tzadok also cites Shabbat 31a, which reads Isaiah 33:6, "And there shall be faith in your times," as referring to the Order of *Zera'im* (Seeds), because one who sows has faith in the Life of the Worlds.

> "Then he says the blessing, 'Blessed are You, etc.,' in direct address, and recognizes that all his enjoyments are from Hashem, blessed be He."
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> אָז יֹאמַר הַבְּרָכָה ... בְּנוֹכָח ... וּמַכִּיר שֶׁכָּל הֲנָאוֹתָיו מֵהַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ
>
> **— Resisei Layla, Siman 5, Seif 1**



A family portrait.

I cannot tell you everything my mother felt in those five and a half years. I was a child, and children do not see all of it. But I can tell you what I saw her do with them. She did not treat the hard years as time to be endured until the real life resumed. She treated them as life. She lived inside the night and she did not stop giving, and that, I now understand, is what Rav Tzadok means by faith as an occupation.

It is also what he did. A man whose first marriage did not work out, and whose home never had children, wrote many books on how the soul lives in this world, and none of them is a complaint. He was a person living by his faith, "even while his work was in darkness."

Not the Doer: Siman 27

Twenty-two simanim later, Rav Tzadok comes back to the same idea from a completely different direction. He is explaining why the Torah forbids work on Shabbos, and his answer is not what most of us expect.

> "A person must know, regarding all his actions and deeds, that he is not the doer, rather everything is by supernal power, and all his actions are from Hashem, blessed be He, as in 'for all our works You have wrought for us.'"
>
> הָאָדָם צָרִיךְ לָדַעַת בְּכָל פְּעֻלּוֹתָיו וּמַעֲשָׂיו שֶׁלֹּא הוּא הַפּוֹעֵל ... רַק הַכֹּל בְּכֹחַ עֶלְיוֹן וְכָל פְּעֻלּוֹתָיו מֵהַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ ... גַּם כָּל מַעֲשֵׂינוּ פָּעַלְתָּ לָנוּ
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> **— Resisei Layla, Siman 27, Seif 1, citing Isaiah 26:12**

That is the reason for Shabbos. For six days a person works, plans, builds, and worries, and it is very easy to start believing that he is the one doing all of it. Then, on Shabbos, he stops. And in the stopping he testifies. The world did not fall apart when his hands rested, because his hands were never the source.[5] Rav Tzadok reads even the verse's phrasing this way: "six days *shall be done*" (*te'aseh*), as if the work gets done on its own.[6]

> "... he testifies about himself that all his actions are from Hashem, blessed be He, and that they happen by themselves, without his own strength or the might of his hand at all."
>
> זֶה מֵעִיד עַל עַצְמוֹ דְּכָל פְּעֻלּוֹתָיו מֵהַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ ... שֶׁהֵם נַעֲשִׂים מֵעַצְמָם שֶׁלֹּא בְּכֹחוֹ וְעֹצֶם יָדוֹ כְּלָל
>
> **— Resisei Layla, Siman 27, Seif 1**

And then he gives a conclusion that I find moving every time I read it. It is not only that Shabbos is permitted *despite* the work of the week. He says that the work of the six days is permitted only *because of* Shabbos.

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5 Isaiah 26:12: "Hashem, You will establish peace for us, for all our works You have also wrought for us."

6 Exodus 35:2: "Six days shall work be done (*te'aseh*), and on the seventh day shall be holy for you." Rav Tzadok reads the form *te'aseh* as work that is "done by itself," and relates it to Exodus 20:9 ("Six days you shall labor"), and to Isaiah 44:5, "and another shall write on his hand 'to Hashem.'"

> "… specifically through the keeping of Shabbos is the work of the six days permitted, since he knows that he is not the doer or the actor at all."
> דְּעַל יְדֵי שְׁמִירַת שַׁבָּת דַּוְוקָא הוּא שֶׁהוּתְּרָה מְלֶאכֶת שִׁשֶּׁת יָמִים … מֵאַחַר שֶׁיּוֹדֵעַ שֶׁאֵין הוּא הָעוֹשֶׂה וְהַפּוֹעֵל כְּלָל
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> **— Resisei Layla, Siman 27, Seif 1**

Think about what that means. We are allowed to labor, to strive, to give everything we have, as long as we know the truth underneath it. The effort is real. The effort is even commanded. But we are never the final cause.



A quiet moment on the couch.



Out together on a parade day.

Nothing strips away the illusion of control faster than a serious illness. My mother lived in that truth for five and a half years in a way most of us never have to. The people around her, the doctors, the family, we children, could all do a great deal, and none of us could do the one thing. I do not say this as a consolation. I say it because Rav Tzadok says it is simply *the truth* about every one of us, in good years as well. And I believe those who see it early are not the weaker for it. They are freer. They stop spending their strength on the question of control, and they can spend all of it on love.

Rav Tzadok knew it from his own life, too. Whether a marriage works and whether a home has children are exactly the things a person does not control. "For all our works You have wrought for us" was, I believe, not only a verse to him. It was how he understood his own story.

The Joy That Is Given: Siman 21

If everything comes from Hashem, then there is one more thing that comes from Him which we usually take to be entirely our own. In Siman 21 Rav Tzadok lists the gifts that Heaven gives a person, and the list begins like this: wisdom in the mind, *joy in the heart*, and success in action. The Talmud teaches that much of this is decreed at the very beginning of a life.[7]

Look at where he puts joy. It is not an achievement. It is a gift, and he says it is the real meaning of wealth.

> "… the joy that is in the heart, which is the essence of wealth."
>
> הַשִּׂמְחָה שֶׁבַּלֵּב, שֶׁהוּא עִיקַּר עֲשִׁירוּת
>
> **— Resisei Layla, Siman 21, Seif 1**

He cites the Mishnah: "Who is rich? One who rejoices in his portion."[8] And he adds a line that turns the usual ledger upside down: if a person has silver like the sand of the sea but lacks gladness of heart, he is called poor.

I think this is the part of Rav Tzadok's life that I find hardest to understand and most worth trying to. A man with his circumstances should, by any ordinary accounting, have been poor. Everything I have learned of him suggests the opposite: a person who lived with real *simchah*, because he knew from where everything comes. He was not rich in what he had. He was rich in how he held it.

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7 Niddah 16b: at conception it is decreed whether the drop will become wise or foolish, rich or poor. Rav Tzadok relates "rich" to the joy of the heart.

8 Pirkei Avot 4:1 ("Who is rich? One who rejoices in his portion"). Rav Tzadok also cites Jerusalem Talmud, Terumot 8:12, "the heart depends on the purse."



At a simchah.

When I look through the photographs from those years, I am struck by how often she is smiling. Not because there was nothing to be afraid of. She was a woman who gave her whole heart to everything she did, and that included joy. She made sure that we had a childhood with warmth in it, even while she was living in the night that Rav Tzadok describes.

That, too, is a form of faith. Gladness in the heart, in the middle of the dark, is a way of saying *I know whose world this is*.

A Real, Eternal Life

Rav Tzadok devoted his writing to one question: how does a person live a life that does not end when the breath ends? His answer, as I read him, is that it begins with the bigger picture. The toil of this world is real, and it is the preparation. The Sages say it in one image: "One who toiled on the eve of Shabbos will eat on Shabbos."[9] This world is the eve of Shabbos. What we put into it, in effort and love and faith, is what we bring to the table.

I want to be careful about one thing. There is a passage in Siman 13 that I have thought about often in connection with hardship, and I do not want to stretch it beyond what Rav

9 Avodah Zarah 3a. Rashi explains that "the eve of Shabbat" is this world. Rav Tzadok cites this at the end of Siman 1.

Tzadok means. There he says that the size of a person's inner struggle is matched by the size of what he is capable of becoming.

> "Whoever has an immense deficiency is also a vessel for extraordinary perfection, if he merits."
>
> וְכָל שֶׁיֵּשׁ בּוֹ חִסָּרוֹן עָצוּם ... הוּא כְּלִי גַּם כֵּן לִשְׁלֵימוּת מֻפְלָג אִם יִזְכֶּה
>
> **— Resisei Layla, Siman 13, Seif 1**[10]

Rav Tzadok is speaking there of the inner struggle with desire and the drives of the soul, not of illness or loss. I would never tell anyone that suffering is a gift. But I do take from the passage something true about the shape of a life: the places where we are most tested are very often the places where we are given the most to build. In my mother's case I saw it in the plainest terms. The more she was asked to carry, the more fully she gave.



A family trip.

The Children We Leave

Rav Tzadok had no children of his own. Yet today, well over a century after his passing, his books are open on tables in yeshivos and homes around the world, and Jews are

10 Sukkah 52a: "Whoever is greater than his fellow, his inclination is greater than he." Rav Tzadok also cites Zohar III 216a on the Generation of the Flood, who were fit to receive the Torah.

learning how to live from them. The Sages teach that "the main offspring of the righteous are their good deeds."[11] His *sefarim* were his children, and they are very much alive.

My mother also left a legacy that cannot be measured by a headstone. She left us the way she saw the world: that time is precious, that every fiber of a person can be given to what matters, and that behind all of it, Someone is giving us everything we have. She poured her life into setting us up for exactly that connection.

I am fifty now, and I still try to hand that on. I run a small publishing house, and I have been translating and annotating *Resisei Layla* so that more people can learn what Rav Tzadok says. It is, in a real way, a continuation of what my mother started in me when I was a boy. Every page of it is, I hope, a good deed in her merit.



A later family portrait.

How to Mark Her Yahrzeit With Me

If you would like to take part in this yahrzeit, here are a few small things.

- **Learn Siman 5.** It is short enough to learn in one sitting. Even a page of it, in my mother's merit, is enough.

11 Rashi on Genesis 6:9, quoting Midrash Bereishit Rabbah 30:6: "The main offspring of the righteous are their good deeds."

• **Say one blessing slowly this week.** When you say *Baruch atah*, stop on the “You.” Remember that you are speaking to the One who gave you what is in your hand.

• **Let Shabbos testify.** Whatever you are carrying this week, put it down on Shabbos on purpose, and let that be your way of saying that it was never yours alone to carry.

• **Light a candle, give tzedakah, and tell a story** about someone you miss.

Three questions I am asking myself this week, which you are welcome to borrow:

• Where am I living as if I were the doer, and what would it change to remember that I am not?

• Where is my night right now, and am I still giving inside it?

• Is there joy in my heart that I have been treating as something I must earn, when it is really a gift?



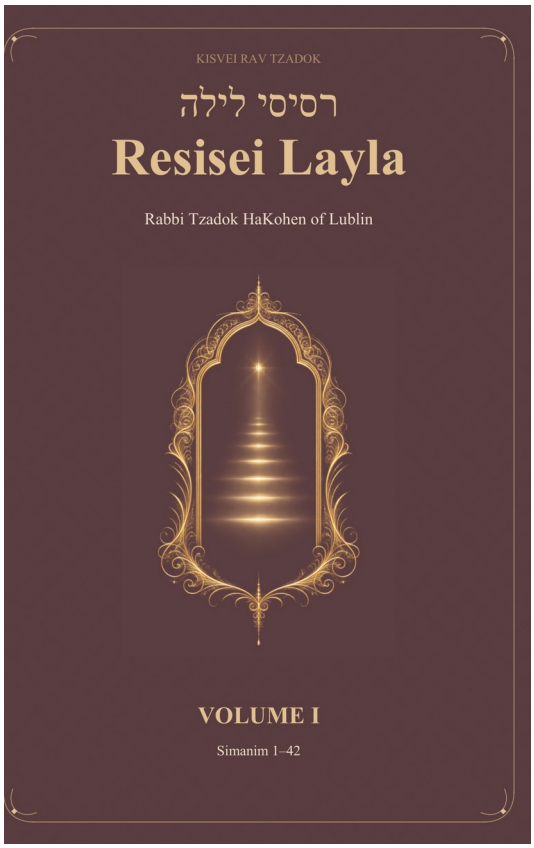
A moment at a simchah.

May her memory be a blessing. *Yehi zichra baruch.*

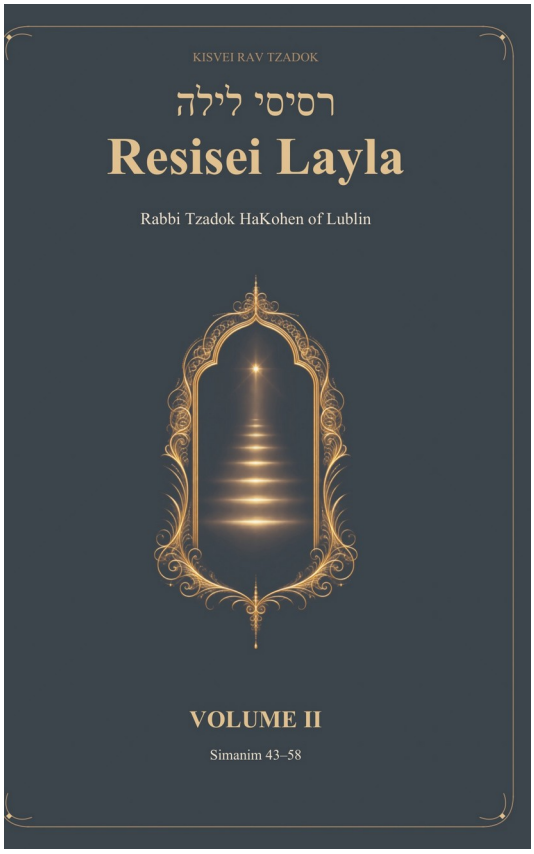
Learn Resisei Layla in My Mother’s Merit

My Hebrew–English interlinear edition of *Resisei Layla* presents Rav Tzadok’s Hebrew with the English translation set beside each phrase, and translates the sources he cites in

the footnotes, so a reader can follow each step of his thought. Every copy that is learned is, I hope, a drop of light in my mother's merit. It is available in two volumes on Amazon.



Volume I · Simanim 1–42



Volume II · Simanim 43–58

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